

GUIDE of the Convent

HISTORY

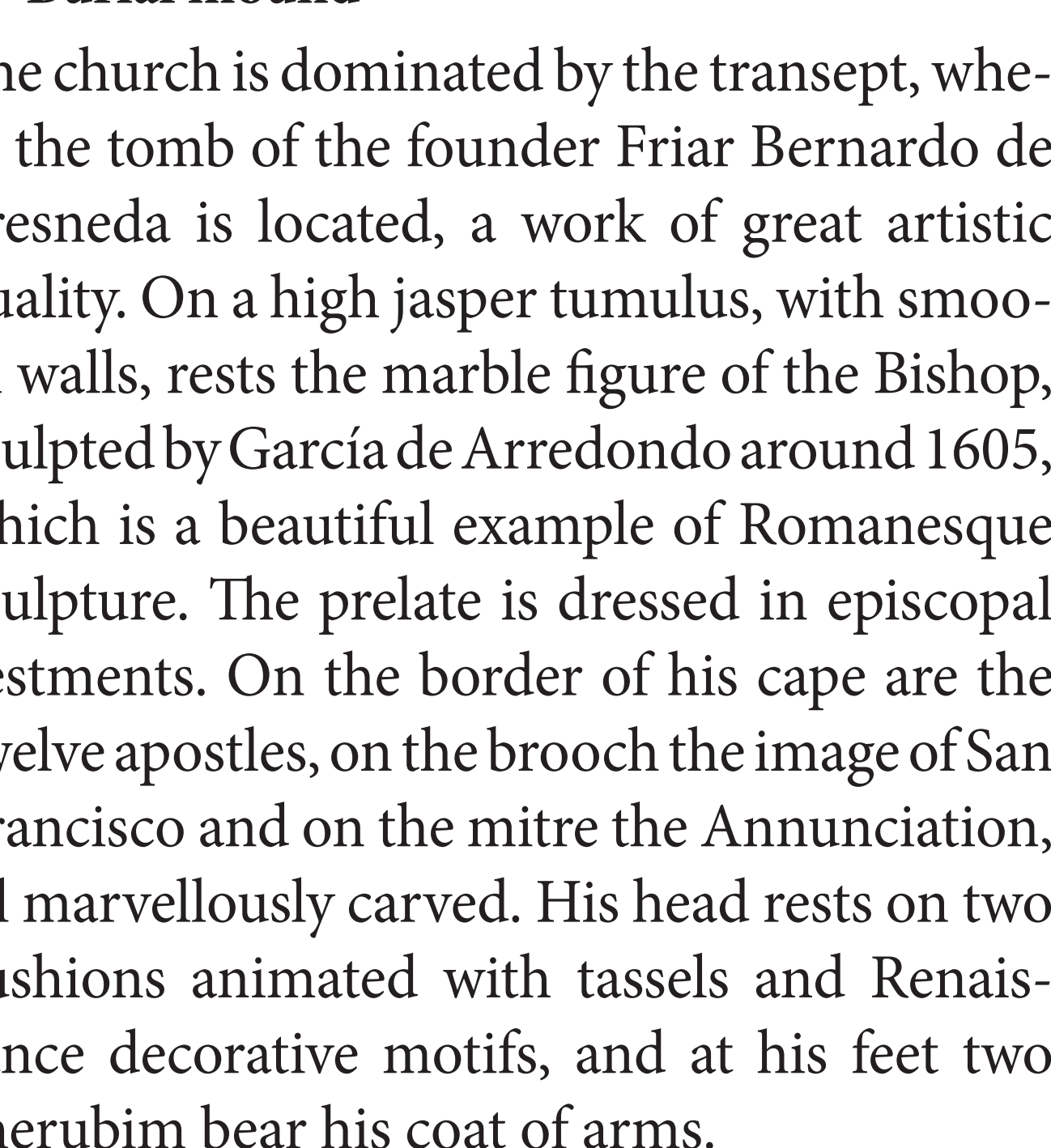
This vast complex is located outside the city walls, to the southwest of the city. History tells us that on 26th February 1535, the Franciscan convent of Nuestra Señora de los Ángeles, founded in 1456 by Captain Iñigo de Zúñiga in Cidamón, moved to this city, settling on a property donated by Juan de Samano. Without doubt, the great benefactor of this house was Friar Bernardo de Fresneda, who was confessor to Charles V and advisor to Philip II, Bishop of Cuenca and Cordoba and, by royal wish, Archbishop-elect of Saragossa. At the end of his life he decided to found a church in this city and “what was annexed to it”, to convert it into his mausoleum and a University College. The deed of foundation was drawn up in 1568.

Friar Bernardo died in 1577 when the enclosure was not yet finished, as the works were not completed until 1592.

The church has a single nave divided into four bays with chapels between the buttresses, a sufficiently well-defined transept both inside and out, and a polygonal chancel preceded by a straight bay. The transept has a vaulted transept with a polychrome coat of arms of Friar Bernardo de Fresneda in the keystone. At the foot there is a high choir that covers the first three bays. The portico that protects the entrance seems to be a 17th century addition. The belfry also dates from this period. This temple, an avant-garde work very close to the Herrerian style, does not forget in its decorative repertoire the well-known Escorial balls to finish off the small exterior buttresses.

It was inhabited by Franciscan friars until the confiscation of Mendizábal. After the confiscation, in 1840, the Town Council managed to get Queen Isabel II to grant it this superb convent. In the absence of the Franciscans since 1835, the church was fitted out to help the parish and in the buildings of the complex, the western part was used as a charity house, a school for boys and girls and an asylum, run by the Daughters of Charity. The eastern area was used as barracks for the Numancia Cavalry regiment, which in 1883 led a failed republican uprising against King Alfonso XII. Later, this area housed the Hall of Residence of the Fathers of the Heart of Mary, where numerous religious were trained until 1968. Today this complex houses an old people's home in the western part, the Diocesan Restoration Workshop in the east and a Parador de Turismo in the centre.

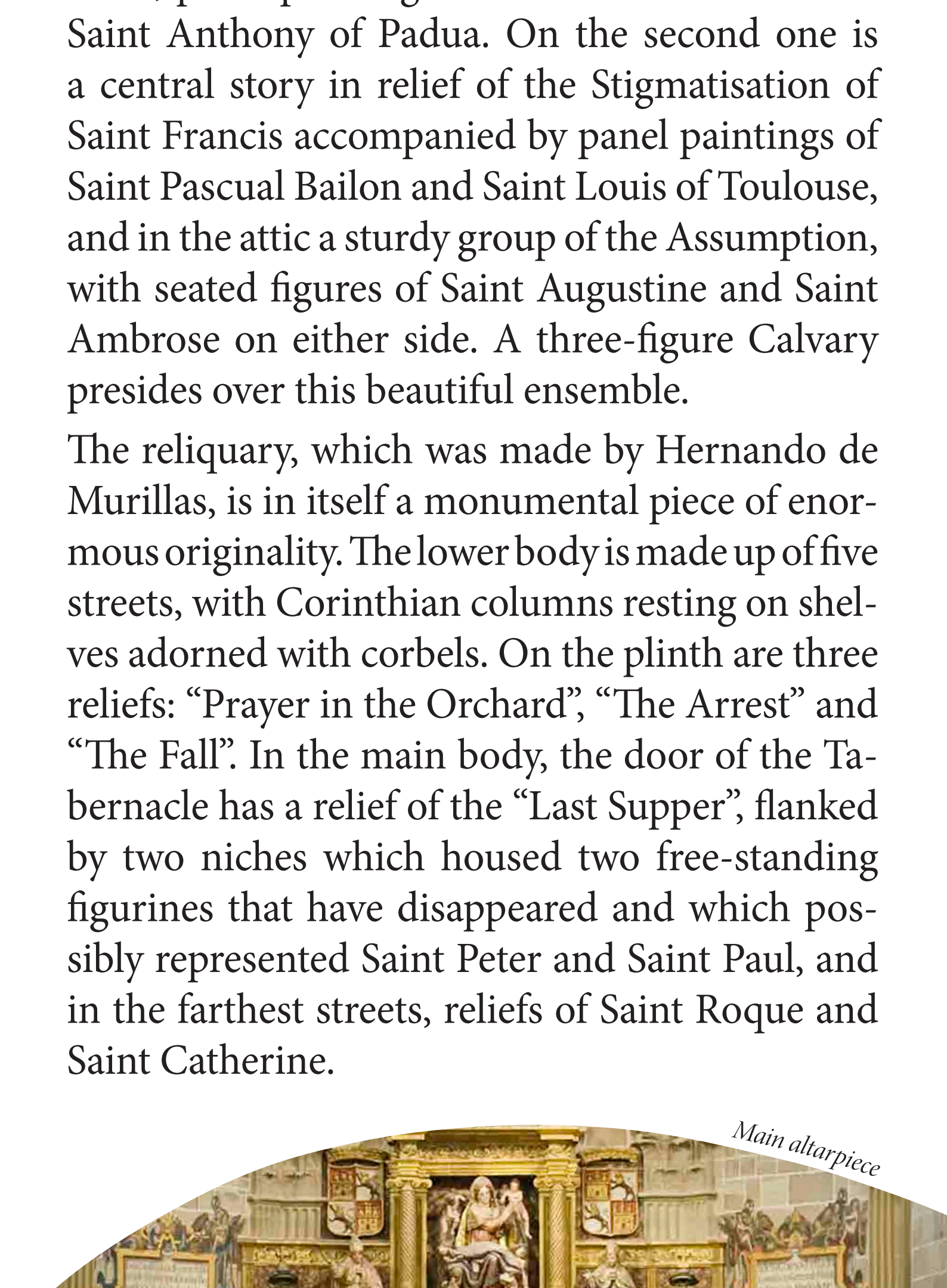
CHURCH PLAN



DESCRIPTION

1.- Burial mound

The church is dominated by the transept, where the tomb of the founder Friar Bernardo de Fresneda is located, a work of great artistic quality. On a high jasper tumulus, with smooth walls, rests the marble figure of the Bishop, sculpted by García de Arredondo around 1605, which is a beautiful example of Romanesque sculpture. The prelate is dressed in episcopal vestments. On the border of his cape are the twelve apostles, on the brooch the image of San Francisco and on the mitre the Annunciation, all marvellously carved. His head rests on two cushions animated with tassels and Renaissance decorative motifs, and at his feet two cherubim bear his coat of arms.



Burial mound of Friar Bernardo de Fresneda

2.- Main Altarpiece

Dominating the entire perspective of the church is the main altarpiece, a magnificent Classicist work made around 1605.

The result of the work of the best regional artists of the time, this altarpiece from Santo Domingo de la Calzada is just one more piece in the context of the main chapel, as its stone architecture (the only one in La Rioja), which forms a backdrop to the masonry work, forms part of the whole ensemble. Relief scenes, freestanding images and panel paintings are incorporated into its construction. Organised in two bodies with three streets and an attic, the altarpiece is capriciously articulated by Ionic columns attached to wide, recessed pilasters. Its central street is the widest and the main part of the iconography is located there. Thus, on the first storey there are landscape scenes in relief of the Lavatory and the Last Supper and, above them, panel paintings of Saint Bonaventure and Saint Anthony of Padua. On the second one is a central story in relief of the Stigmatisation of Saint Francis accompanied by panel paintings of Saint Pascual Bailon and Saint Louis of Toulouse, and in the attic a sturdy group of the Assumption, with seated figures of Saint Augustine and Saint Ambrose on either side. A three-figure Calvary presides over this beautiful ensemble.

The reliquary, which was made by Hernando de Murillas, is in itself a monumental piece of enormous originality. The lower body is made up of five streets, with Corinthian columns resting on shelves adorned with corbels. On the plinth are three reliefs: “Prayer in the Orchard”, “The Arrest” and “The Fall”. In the main body, the door of the Tabernacle has a relief of the “Last Supper”, flanked by two niches which housed two free-standing figurines that have disappeared and which possibly represented Saint Peter and Saint Paul, and in the farthest streets, reliefs of Saint Roque and Saint Catherine.



Main altarpiece

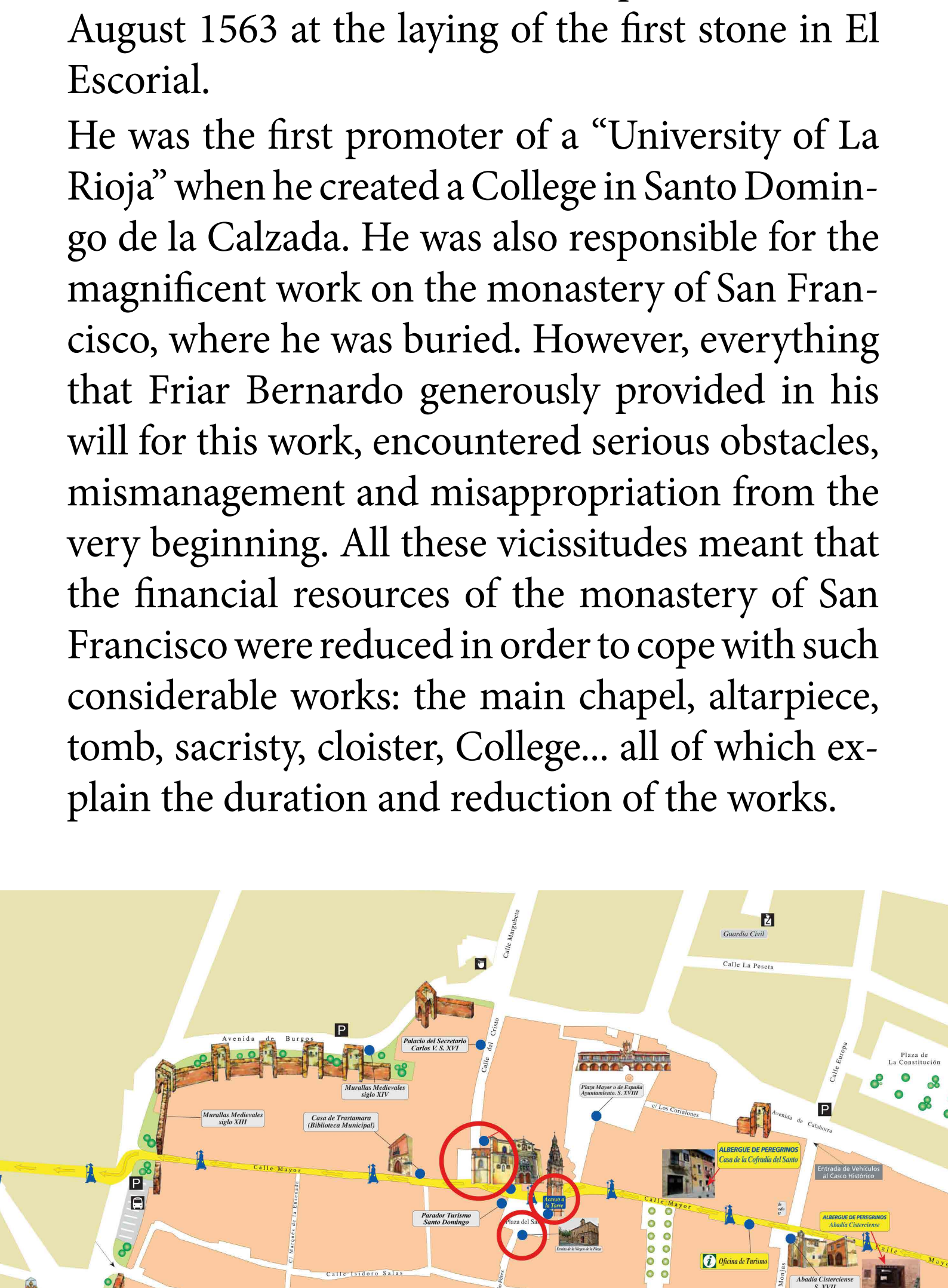
3.- Christ Altarpiece

This altarpiece was moved from the north chapel of the Cathedral transept (today the main altarpiece occupies this space).

It is a 17th century Baroque altarpiece, the work of Manuel de Puelles, consisting of a bench, which in its central area has two doors simulating a sepulchre to house the image of the recumbent Christ. The body is made up of three streets divided by Solomonic columns with grapes and a semicircular attic. In the central street there is a life-size crucifix and behind it a painting of the city of Jerusalem.

In the street to the right of the viewer Christ tied to the column and scourged and to the left a reproduction of the carving of Veronica, from the 15th century, which is kept in the Cathedral.

This set of images was the setting for the services held around the Passion of Christ by the Brotherhood of the Vera Cruz. Its location in the Church of the Franciscan convent reminds us that it was in this place that these devotions were born, although for centuries they passed to the Cathedral and today they have returned to their place of origin.



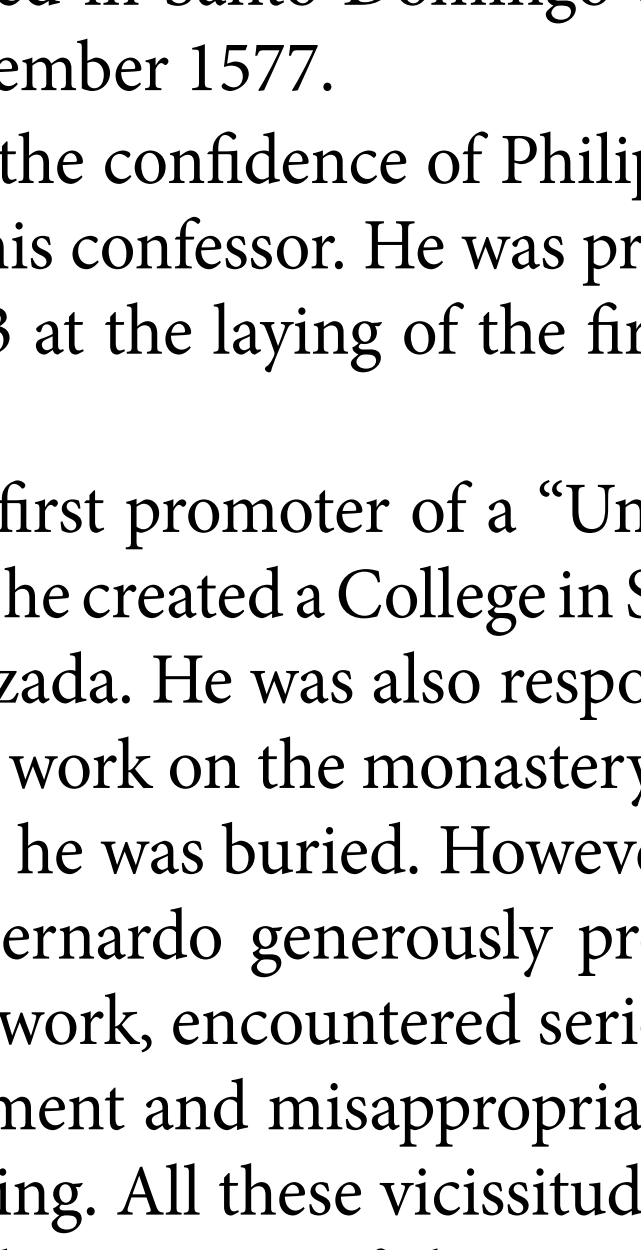
Christ Altarpiece

4.- Museum

The platforms and some of the rooms in the upper cloister of the convent of San Francisco are used for exhibitions. Visitors can enjoy the view of pieces and collections that are normally kept in private rooms. In this exhibition area, various collections with different motifs that have been donated to the cathedral's patrimony stand out, as well as the collection of the artist Teresa Peña, which is kept on deposit. The magnificent collection of ivories, divided into two rooms, one dedicated to pieces with a Christian religious theme and the other to pieces with a profane theme or from pagan cults, is of particular value. In total there are more than 100 ivory sculptures, all of them of great value both for the material they were made of and for their antiquity. Some are exquisitely crafted and others stand out for their large dimensions.

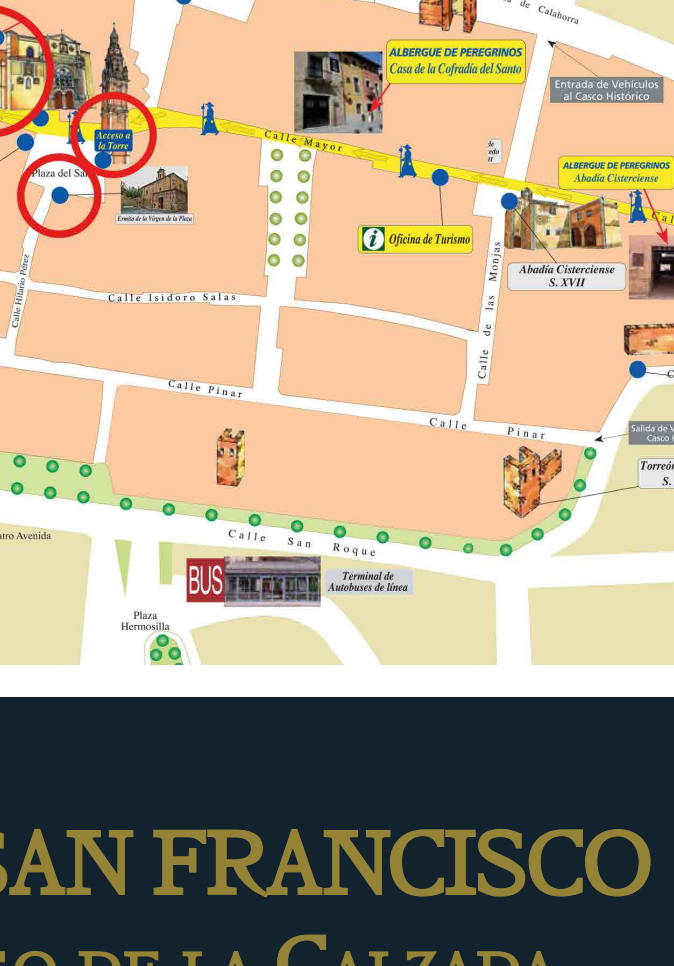
The technique, origin and characteristics of the sculptures are explained on panels that accompany the visitor through the rooms.

Religious ivory room



FRIAR BERNARDO DE FRESNEDA

Archbishop Friar Bernardo de Fresneda was born in the town of Fresneda, today the province of Burgos, around 1510. He was professed in the Franciscan convent of Nuestra Señora de los Ángeles in Cidamón, a convent that



was transferred to the city of Santo Domingo de la Calzada in 1535. He was Commissioner General of the Crusade Council and Bishop of Cuenca and Cordoba. He rejected the see of Toledo and accepted, at the King's special wish, that of Saragossa. On his way to take up his new see of Saragossa, he died in Santo Domingo de la Calzada on 21st December 1577.

He enjoyed the confidence of Philip II, of whom he became his confessor. He was present on 20th August 1563 at the laying of the first stone in El Escorial.

He was the first promoter of a “University of La Rioja” when he created a College in Santo Domingo de la Calzada. He was also responsible for the magnificent work on the monastery of San Francisco, where he was buried. However, everything that Friar Bernardo generously provided in his will for this work, encountered serious obstacles, mismanagement and misappropriation from the very beginning. All these vicissitudes meant that the financial resources of the monastery of San Francisco were reduced in order to cope with such considerable works: the main chapel, altarpiece, tomb, sacristy, cloister, College... all of which explain the duration and reduction of the works.

**CONVENTO DE SAN FRANCISCO
DE SANTO DOMINGO DE LA CALZADA**

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